

WEEK 14

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 17: 1 – 10, 23b – 26, 40 – 51*

The fight of David against Goliath.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Now the Philistines gathered their armies for battle; and they were gathered at Socoh, which belongs to Judah, and encamped between Socoh and Aze'kah, in E'phes-dam'mim. And Saul and the men of Israel were gathered, and encamped in the valley of Elah, and drew up in line of battle against the Philistines. And the Philistines stood on the mountain on the one side, and Israel stood on the mountain on the other side, with a valley between them.

And there came out from the camp of the Philistines a champion named Goliath, of Gath, whose height was six cubits and a span. He had a helmet of bronze on his head, and he was armed with a coat of mail, and the weight of the coat was five thousand shekels of bronze. And he had greaves of bronze upon his legs, and a javelin of bronze slung between his shoulders. And the shaft of his spear was like a weaver's beam, and his spear's head weighed six hundred shekels of iron; and his shield-bearer went before him. He stood and shouted to the ranks of Israel, "Why have you come out to draw up for battle? Am I not a Philistine, and are you not servants of Saul? Choose a man for yourselves, and let him come down to me. If he is able to fight with me and kill me, then we will be your servants; but if I prevail against him and kill him, then you shall be our servants and serve us." And the Philistine said, "I defy the ranks of Israel this day; give me a man, that we may fight together."

As he talked with them, behold, the champion, the Philistine of Gath, Goliath by name, came up out of the ranks of the Philistines, and spoke the same words as before. And David heard him. All the men of Israel, when they saw the man, fled from him, and were much afraid.

And the men of Israel said, "Have you seen this man who has come up? Surely he has come up to defy Israel; and the man who kills him, the king will enrich with great riches, and will give him his daughter, and make his father's house free in Israel." And David said to the men who stood by him,

"What shall be done for the man who kills this Philistine, and takes away the reproach from Israel? For who is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he should defy the armies of the living God?" Then he took his staff in his hand, and chose five smooth stones from the brook, and put them in his shepherd's bag or wallet; his sling was in his hand, and he drew near to the Philistine.

And the Philistine came on and drew near to David, with his shield-bearer in front of him. And when the Philistine looked, and saw David, he disdained him; for he was but a youth, ruddy and comely in appearance. And the Philistine said to David, "Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?" And the Philistine cursed David by his gods. The Philistine said to David, "Come to me, and I will give your flesh to the birds of the air and to the beasts of the field." Then David said to the Philistine, "You come to me with a sword and with a spear and with a javelin; but I come to you in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied. This day the LORD will deliver you into my hand, and I will strike you down, and cut off your head; and I will give the dead bodies of the host of the Philistines this day to the birds of the air and to the wild beasts of the earth; that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel, and that all this assembly may know that the LORD saves not with sword and spear; for the battle is the LORD'S and he will give you into our hand." When the Philistine arose and came and drew near to meet David, David ran quickly toward the battle line to meet the Philistine. And David put his hand in his bag and took out a stone, and slung it, and struck the Philistine on his forehead; the stone sank into his forehead, and he fell on his face to the ground. So David prevailed over the Philistine with a sling and with a stone, and struck the Philistine, and killed him; there was no sword in the hand of David. Then David ran and stood over the Philistine, and took his sword and drew it out of its sheath, and killed him, and cut off his head with it. When the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled.

Responsorial. *Cfr. 1 Sam. 17: 37; Ps. 56: 4-5*

R: The Lord has freed me from the claws of the lion and from the claws of the bear. * He will free me from the hands of my enemies.

V: God sends his faithfulness and his grace: I am as if in the midst of lions.

R: He will free me from the hands of my enemies.

Second Reading. Ps. 148: 1 – 2

Do not stop living well and you will always praise God,

A reading from the “Commentary on the psalms” of St. Augustine, bishop.

The subject of our meditation in this present life should be the praises of God; for the everlasting exaltation of our life hereafter will be the praise of God, and none can become fit for the life hereafter, who has not practiced himself for it now. So then now we praise God, but we pray to Him too.

Our praise is marked by joy, our prayer by groans. He has promised us in fact something that we do not have as yet and, since he who has promised it is truthful, we enjoy in hope; yet we do not possess it as yet, therefore we groan in desire. It is a good thing for us to persevere in desire, until the promise is fulfilled and the groans having terminated there follows uniquely the praise. On account of this there are two seasons, one, that which now is in the temptations and tribulations of this life, the other, that which is to be hereafter in everlasting rest and exultation; we have established also the celebration of two seasons, that before Passover and that after Passover.

That which is before Passover signifies tribulation, in which we now are; that which we are now keeping after Passover, signifies the bliss in which we shall hereafter be.

The celebration then which we keep before Passover is what we do now: by that which we keep after Passover we signify what as yet we have not. Therefore we employ that time in fasting and prayer, this present time we spend in praises, and relax our fast.

This is the Alleluia that we sing, which, as you know, means (in Latin), Praise the Lord. Therefore that period is before the Lord's Resurrection, this, after His Resurrection: by which time is signified the future hope which as yet we have not: for what we represent after the Lord's Resurrection, we shall have after our own. For in our Head both are figured, both are set forth. The Passion of the Lord sets forth to us this present life of trial, for in it we must toil, be harassed, and, at last, die; but the Resurrection and Glorification of the Lord sets forth to us the life which we

are to have hereafter, when He shall come to recompense due rewards, evil to the evil, good to the good.

And now indeed all the evil men sing with us, Alleluia; but, if they persevere in their wickedness, they may utter with their lips the song of our life hereafter; but the life itself, which will then be in the reality which now is typified, they cannot obtain, because they would not practice it before it came, and lay hold on what was to come.

“Alleluia.” “Praise the Lord,” you say to your neighbour, he to you: when all are exhorting each other, all are doing what they exhort others to do. But praise with your whole selves: that is, let not your tongue and voice alone praise God, but your conscience also, your life, your deeds.

For now, when we are gathered together in the Church, we praise: when we go forth each to his own business, we seem to cease to praise God. Let a man not cease to live well, and then he will always praise God.

Responsorial. *Ps. 21: 23; 56: 10*

R: I will announce your name to my brothers, alleluia, * I will praise you in the midst of the assembly, alleluia, alleluia.

V: I will praise you among the nations, Lord, to you I will sing hymns among the peoples.

R: I will praise you in the midst of the assembly, alleluia, alleluia.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 1:1 – 7, 20 – 32*

Exhortation to search for Wisdom.

A reading from the book of Proverbs.

The proverbs of Solomon, son of David, king of Israel: That men may know wisdom and instruction, understand words of insight, receive instruction in wise dealing, righteousness, justice, and equity; that prudence may be given to the simple, knowledge and discretion to the youth -- the wise man also may hear and increase in learning, and the man of understanding acquire skill, to understand a proverb and a figure, the words of the wise and their riddles. The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction.

Wisdom cries aloud in the street; in the markets she raises her voice; on the top of the walls she cries out; at the entrance of the city gates she speaks: "How long, O simple ones, will you love being simple? How long will scoffers delight in their scoffing and fools hate knowledge? Give heed to my reproof; behold, I will pour out my thoughts to you; I will make my words known to you.

Because I have called and you refused to listen, have stretched out my hand and no one has heeded, and you have ignored all my counsel and would have none of my reproof, I also will laugh at your calamity; I will mock when panic strikes you, when panic strikes you like a storm, and your calamity comes like a whirlwind, when distress and anguish come upon you.

Then they will call upon me, but I will not answer; they will seek me diligently but will not find me. Because they hated knowledge and did not choose the fear of the LORD, would have none of my counsel, and despised all my reproof, therefore they shall eat the fruit of their way and be sated with their own devices.

For the simple are killed by their turning away, and the complacency of fools destroys them; but he who listens to me will dwell secure and will be at ease, without dread of evil."

Responsorial. 1 Cor. 3: 18-19; 1: 23. 24

R: If anyone among you believes himself to be wise in this world, let him make himself a fool in order to become wise: * the wisdom of this world is foolishness in front of God.

V: We preach Christ crucified, power of God and wisdom of God:

R: the wisdom of this world is foolishness in front of God.

Second Reading. 1: 18 – 19

The word of God is the inexhaustible spring of life.

A reading from the "Commentary on the Diatessaron" of St. Ephraim, deacon.

Lord, who can grasp all the wealth of just one of your words? What we understand is much less than what we leave behind, like thirsty people who drink from a fountain. For your word, Lord, has many shades of meaning just as those who study it have many different points of view. The Lord has

coloured his words with many hues so that each person who studies it can see in it what he loves. He has hidden many treasures in his word so that each of us is enriched as we meditate on it.

The word of God is a tree of life that from all its parts offers you fruits that are blessed. It is like that rock opened in the desert that from all its parts gave forth a spiritual drink. As the Apostle says, 'All ate the same supernatural food and all drank the same supernatural drink'.

He who comes into contact with some share of its treasure should not think that the only thing contained in the word is what he himself has found. He should realize that he has only been able to find that one thing from among many others. Nor, because only that one part has become his, should he say that the word is void and empty and look down on it; but because he could not exhaust it he should give thanks for its riches. Be glad that you were overcome and do not be sad that it overcame you. The thirsty man rejoices when he drinks and he is not downcast because he cannot empty the fountain. Rather let the fountain quench your thirst than have your thirst quench the fountain. Because if your thirst is quenched and the fountain is not exhausted you can drink from it again whenever you are thirsty. But if when your thirst is quenched the fountain also is dried up your victory will bode evil for you.

Be grateful for what you have received and do not grumble about the abundance left behind. What you have received and what you have reached is your share, what remains is your heritage. What, at one time, you are not able to receive because of your weakness, you will be able to receive at other times if you persevere. Do not have the presumption to try and take in one draught what cannot be taken in one draught, and do not abandon out of laziness what you may only consume little by little.

Responsorial. *1 Pet. 1: 25; cfr. Bar. 4: 1*

R: The word of the Lord remains forever. * What is this word? It is the Good News that has been brought to you.

V: This is the book of the commandments of God, the Law that stands forever, those who keep it live.

R: What is this word? It is the Good News that has been brought to you.

YEAR A

Gospel. Mt. 11: 25-30

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

At that time Jesus said, "I thank you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because you have hidden these things from the wise and the intelligent and have revealed them to infants; yes, Father, for such was your gracious will. My Father has handed over all things to me; and no one knows the Son except the Father, and no one knows the Father except the Son and anyone to whom the Son chooses to reveal him. "Come to me, all you that are weary and are carrying heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light."

Third Reading. Hom. 1, 5

Let us imitate the Lord.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. John Chrysostom, bishop.

Let us imitate the Lord praying for our enemies. Imitate the Lord: he hung on the cross and begged the Father for his crucifiers. And how can I be similar to the Lord you will say? If you want, you can: if it was not possible for you to imitate him, how could he have said: "Learn from me, for I am meek and humble of heart" (Mt. 11: 29)? If you were not capable of being similar to him, Paul would not have said: "Make yourselves my imitators, as I am of Christ" (1 Cor. 11: 1).

For the rest, if you want to imitate the Lord, follow the example of his servant Stephen: he in fact truly imitated him. Like Christ in the midst of his crucifiers prayed to the Father, so also the servant among those who were stoning him, insulted by every one, while he received the blows of the stones, offered the pain with which he was tormented saying: "Lord, do not hold this sin against them" (Act. 7: 60).

Do you want me to show you another servant of the Lord, who bore pains that were even more serious? It is Paul who said: "I have been beaten three times with the rods by the Jews, once I have been stoned, three times I have been shipwrecked, I have spent a day and a night at the mercy of the waves" (2 Cor. 11: 25). And what did he say after all this? "For I could wish that I myself were cut off from Christ for the sake of my brothers, those of my own race, the people of Israel" (Rm. 9: 3). Do you want me to point out

to you someone else, not of the New but of the Old Testament? This in fact is the most wonderful thing; that those who had not yet been commanded to love their enemies, but on the contrary to answer evil with evil, that is eye for eye and tooth for tooth, could perhaps reach a spirituality that was worthy of the apostles.

Listen to what Moses, who was often stoned and despised by the Jews, says: "But now, if you will only forgive their sin--but if not, blot me out of the book that you have written." (Ex. 32: 32).

Do you not see how the just man preferred the salvation of the others to his own? If you have not sinned, why do you want to be a participant in their punishment? Because, he answers, when the others suffer, I do not care about my happiness.

What forgiveness could we achieve if, while the Lord and the servants of the New and Old Testament exhort us to pray for our enemies, we instead curse them? I beg you, brothers not to do this. Otherwise, the greater and more numerous the examples, the greater will be the punishment if we do not imitate them. It is better to pray for the enemies than for the friends, because the merit is greater.

"In fact – he says – if you love those who love you, what reward will you get? Are not the tax collectors doing that?" (Mt. 5: 46).

If we pray only for the friends, we are therefore not better than the pagans and the tax collectors. But if we love the enemies we become, for as much as it is possible for man, similar to God "who makes his sun rise over the wicked and above the good, and who makes his rain fall over the just and the unjust" (Mt. 5: 45). Let us therefore be similar to the Father: "Be perfect –says the Lord – as your heavenly Father is perfect" (Mt. 5: 48), in order to earn the kingdom of heaven through the grace and benevolence of the Lord God and our Saviour Jesus Christ, to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Mt. 11: 29, 30, 28*

R: Take my yoke upon you, says the Lord, and learn from me for I am meek and humble of heart. * My yoke in fact is sweet and my burden light.

V: Come to me, all of you, who are weary and oppressed, and I will give you rest.

R: My yoke in fact is sweet and my burden light.

YEAR B

Gospel. Mk. 6: 1-6

A reading from the Gospel of St. Mark.

He left that place and came to his hometown, and his disciples followed him. On the Sabbath he began to teach in the synagogue, and many who heard him were astounded. They said, "Where did this man get all this? What is this wisdom that has been given to him? What deeds of power are being done by his hands! Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary and brother of James and Joset and Judas and Simon, and are not his sisters here with us?" And they took offence at him.

Then Jesus said to them, "Prophets are not without honour, except in their hometown, and among their own kin, and in their own house." And he could do no deed of power there, except that he laid his hands on a few sick people and cured them. And he was amazed at their unbelief. Then he went about among the villages teaching.

He called the twelve and began to send them out two by two, and gave them authority over the unclean spirits.

Third Reading. Tratt. 31: 3-4

The Father himself has sent me.

A reading from the Treatise "On the Gospel of St. John" of St. Augustine, bishop.

Listen to the word of the Lord, brothers, and consider in what way he confirmed it and how he answered to those who said: "But we know where this man is from; when the Christ comes no one will know where he is from" (Jn. 7: 27). Jesus then, while he taught in the temple, exclaimed: "Yes, you know me, and you know where I am from. Yet I am not here on my own, but he who sent me is true. You do not know him, but I know him because I am from him and he sent me" (Jn. 7: 28). It is as if he says: You know me and you don't know me. You know where I come from and you do not know. You know from where I come: I am Jesus of Nazareth, you know my parents also. In this was hidden only the mystery of the childbirth of the Virgin, of which above all only the husband could witness to; he only in fact could indicate faithfully how it had come about, being the only one

who could know it in the quality of husband. Making therefore an exception of the childbirth of the Virgin, they knew everything about Jesus in as much as he was man; his face was known, his birthplace was known, his origins, it was known where he had been born. With reason therefore did he say: “Certainly you know me and you know from where I come” with regard to his human nature and to his physical aspect. But in relation to his divinity: “Yet I have not come here on my own, but he who sent me is true, and you do not know him”. In order to know him, believe in the one whom he has sent, and you will know him; in fact: “No one has ever seen God: it is his Only begotten Son who is in the womb of the Father, who has revealed him” (Jn. 1: 18); and “no one knows the Father if not the Son and those to whom the Son chooses to reveal him” (Mt. 11: 27).

Finally, having said: “He who sent me is true, and you do not know him” in order to show them how they could know him whom they had never seen, he adds: “I however know him” (Jn. 7: 29). Therefore, in order to know him ask me. But why do I know him? “Because I come from him, and he has sent me” (Jn. 7: 29). Admire how he shows the one and the other: “I come from him” he says, because the Son is from the Father, and all that the Son is, belongs to Him of whom the Son is.

For this we say that the Lord is God from God: we do not say that the Father is God from God, but only that he is God. And we say that the Lord Jesus is light from light; we do not say that the Father is light from light, but only that he is light. For this he said: “I come from him”.

“And he has sent me” in this way as you see me in a human body. When he says: “He has sent me” he does not mean a diversity of nature, but the Father who generates him.

Responsorial. *Is. 61: 1; Jn. 8: 42*

R: The Spirit of the Lord is upon me; because the Lord has consecrated me with the anointing: he has sent me to bring the good news to the poor, * to bind the wounds of the broken hearts, to proclaim liberty to the slaves, release to the prisoners.

V: I came from God and am here, I have not come on my own, but he sent me

R: to bind the wounds of the broken hearts, to proclaim liberty to the slaves, release to the prisoners.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 10: 1-12, 17-20*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

After this the Lord appointed seventy others and sent them on ahead of him in pairs to every town and place where he himself intended to go. He said to them, "The harvest is plentiful, but the labourers are few; therefore ask the Lord of the harvest to send out labourers into his harvest. Go on your way. See, I am sending you out like lambs into the midst of wolves. Carry no purse, no bag, no sandals; and greet no one on the road. Whatever house you enter, first say, 'Peace to this house!' And if anyone is there who shares in peace, your peace will rest on that person; but if not, it will return to you. Remain in the same house, eating and drinking whatever they provide, for the labourer deserves to be paid. Do not move about from house to house. Whenever you enter a town and its people welcome you, eat what is set before you; cure the sick who are there, and say to them, 'The kingdom of God has come near to you.' But whenever you enter a town and they do not welcome you, go out into its streets and say, 'Even the dust of your town that clings to our feet, we wipe off in protest against you. Yet know this: the kingdom of God has come near.' I tell you, on that day it will be more tolerable for Sodom than for that town.

"Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! For if the deeds of power done in you had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago, sitting in sackcloth and ashes.

The seventy returned with joy, saying, "Lord, in your name even the demons submit to us!" He said to them, "I watched Satan fall from heaven like a flash of lightning. See, I have given you authority to tread on snakes and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy; and nothing will hurt you. Nevertheless, do not rejoice at this, that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven."

Third Reading. *Disc. 101: 1, 2, 3, 11*

Christ sends his reapers with the sickle of the gospel.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Augustine, bishop.

In the reading of the gospel that has now been announced we have been invited to search for the harvest of which the Lord says: “the harvest is large, but the labourers are few. Pray therefore to the lord of the harvest, to send labourers for his harvest” (Lk. 10: 2). It was then that to his twelve disciples, whom he called apostles, that he added seventy-two others and sent all of them, as it appears from his words, to the harvest that was already ready. Which therefore was this harvest? Certainly not among the pagan nations where nothing had as yet been sown. It is easy therefore to understand that it was the Jewish people. To that harvest the Lord of the harvest came, to that harvest he sent the reapers; to the Gentiles instead he did not send the reapers, but the sowers. Let us understand therefore that the harvest is carried out in the Hebrew people, among the Gentiles, instead, the sowing. From that harvest the apostles have been chosen, when it was already ready for the harvest, because the prophets had sown before. It is beautiful to admire the cultivation of God, to be comforted by his gifts and by those who work in his field.

Be attentive therefore to admire with me the cultivation of God, and in it two harvests: one that belongs to the past, the other to the future; that of the past in the Hebrew nation, that of the future in the pagan nations. Let us give a confirmation of this: from where do the harvests come, if not from the Scripture of the Lord God? Behold, we find written in the present chapter: “The harvest is great, but the labourers are few. Pray therefore to the lord of the harvest, that he send labourers to his harvest”. In another place the Lord says to his disciples: You say that the summer is still far away: “Lift up your eyes and look at the fields that are already ripe for the harvest” (Jn. 4: 35).

And he adds: “Others have laboured and you have taken over their work” (Jn. 4:38). Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, the prophets worked; they worked sowing: at the coming of the Lord the harvest was found to be mature. The reapers, sent with the sickle of the gospel, carry the sheaves into the farmyard of the Lord, there where Stephen would have been threshed.

And behold at this point Paul, who was sent to the Gentiles, intervenes; and he does not hide it, making on the contrary the grace that he had received in a particular and personal form count. In his letters in fact he affirms that he has been sent to preach the gospel there where Christ was not known. But since that harvest is already ready, we turn our attention to

that harvest which we are: the apostles and the prophets have already sown; the Lord himself has sown, since he was present in the apostles, therefore the same Christ himself has made the harvest. They in fact are nothing without him; he instead is complete even without them. For this he says: “Without me you cannot do anything” (Jn.15: 5).

Sowing therefore also among the Gentiles the Christ said: “The sower went out to sow” (Lk. 8: 5) and there he sent the reapers to reap. They are the apostles of Christ, preachers of the gospel, who do not greet anyone along the way (cfr. Lk. 10: 4), that is they do not search for nor do anything else other than announce with brotherly charity the gospel; they arrive in the houses and they say: “Peace to this house” (Lk. 10: 5). They do not say it only with the mouth, but they pour forth that with which they are full; they preach peace because they possess it. He who is full of peace, greets: “Peace to this house” and “if a man of peace is there, your peace will rest on him” (Lk. 10: 5-6).

Responsorial. *1 Th. 2: 4, 12*

R: We speak as men approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel, * we are not trying to please men but God, who tests our hearts.

V: Encouraging, comforting and urging you to live lives worthy of God, who calls you into his kingdom and glory,

R: we are not trying to please men but God, who tests our hearts.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 17: 57 – 18: 9, 20 – 30*

Envy of Saul towards David.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

And as David returned from the slaughter of the Philistine, Abner took him, and brought him before Saul with the head of the Philistine in his hand. And Saul said to him, "Whose son are you, young man?" And David answered, "I am the son of your servant Jesse the Bethlehemite."

When he had finished speaking to Saul, the soul of Jonathan was knit to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as his own soul. And Saul took him that day, and would not let him return to his father's house. Then Jonathan made a covenant with David, because he loved him as his own soul. And Jonathan stripped himself of the robe that was upon him, and gave it to David, and his armour, and even his sword and his bow and his girdle. And David went out and was successful wherever Saul sent him; so that Saul set him over the men of war. And this was good in the sight of all the people and also in the sight of Saul's servants.

As they were coming home, when David returned from slaying the Philistine, the women came out of all the cities of Israel, singing and dancing, to meet King Saul, with timbrels, with songs of joy, and with instruments of music. And the women sang to one another as they made merry, "Saul has slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands."

And Saul was very angry, and this saying displeased him; he said, "They have ascribed to David ten thousands, and to me they have ascribed thousands; and what more can he have but the kingdom?" And Saul eyed David from that day on.

Now Saul's daughter Michal loved David; and they told Saul, and the thing pleased him. Saul thought, "Let me give her to him, that she may be a snare for him, and that the hand of the Philistines may be against him." Therefore Saul said to David a second time, "You shall now be my son-in-law." And Saul commanded his servants, "Speak to David in private and say, 'Behold, the king has delight in you, and all his servants love you; now then become the king's son-in-law.'" And Saul's servants spoke those words

in the ears of David. And David said, "Does it seem to you a little thing to become the king's son-in-law, seeing that I am a poor man and of no repute?" And the servants of Saul told him, "Thus and so did David speak." Then Saul said, "Thus shall you say to David, `The king desires no marriage present except a hundred foreskins of the Philistines, that he may be avenged of the king's enemies.'" Now Saul thought to make David fall by the hand of the Philistines. And when his servants told David these words, it pleased David well to be the king's son-in-law. Before the time had expired, David arose and went, along with his men, and killed two hundred of the Philistines; and David brought their foreskins, which were given in full number to the king, that he might become the king's son-in-law. And Saul gave him his daughter Michal for a wife. But when Saul saw and knew that the LORD was with David, and that all Israel loved him, Saul was still more afraid of David. So Saul was David's enemy continually. Then the princes of the Philistines came out to battle, and as often as they came out David had more success than all the servants of Saul; so that his name was highly esteemed.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ps. 55: 2, 4, 14*

R: Have pity on me, O God, man tramples me down, an aggressor always oppresses me. * In you have I placed all my hope.

V: You have freed me from death, you have preserved my feet from stumbling.

R: In you have I placed all my hope.

Second Reading. *Disc. 1 : 1 – 4:2*

The blessed David was the figure of Christ.

A reading from the “Discourses about David and Goliath” of St. Hippolytus, presbyter.

To those who read the sacred books with faith it is easy to understand the mysteries that regard the blessed David in the old covenant, he who in the psalms was a prophet and saint in works. Who would not admire David, who from his childhood showed in his heart the mysteries of Christ? Or who would not marvel at seeing his prophecies fulfilled? He was elected by God as a just king and prophet, in order to give us a greater certainty not only of the present and of the past, but also of the future. And what will I

praise first of all in him: the boldness of the works and the prophetic words? We find in fact that in both these things, in the words and in the works, this prophet is the figure of the Lord. I see him a shepherd of the sheep, I know that he was anointed king in secret, and I observe the tyrant by whom he is prostrated. I know that the battle thus reaches its end and I see the people freed from slavery; after this I see David unpopular with Saul, forced to flee and cast out as an enemy and offender, hiding himself in the desert; until exactly he who before was hated by Saul is constituted king over Israel.

Now who would not proclaim as blessed the just patriarchs, who not only prophesied the future with words, but suffering themselves, realized in their deeds that which would happen to the Christ? And we must understand in the reality all that is proposed to us, those things that is, which are manifested spiritually with words or with deeds to the blessed prophets. Those figures and those deeds were in reference to the future, they referred that is to he who would come at the end of time to bring to perfection the law and the prophets. He came into the world to teach justice, manifesting himself to us through the gospel, he who said: "I am the way, the truth and the life" (Jn. 14: 6); he in fact was the true just man, the truth, the Saviour of everyone. How can it not be understood that all that was done previously by the blessed David, was then brought to fulfilment by the Saviour and given finally through grace as a gift to the holy Church? Two were those who were anointed by Samuel; one Saul and one David. Saul received the anointing with respect, not however as a man worthy of God but as a transgressor of the law: and God with disdain put him as an oppressor over those who had asked for a king. In the same way Herod, a man who was a transgressor of the law, ruled over sinful men. David then was anointed secretly in Bethlehem, because in Bethlehem the king of heaven would have been born, and there, not secretly anointed by the Father, he manifested himself to the world, as the prophet said: "God, your God has consecrated you with the oil of gladness, above other kings" (Ps. 44: 8).

Saul was anointed with a horn of clay, because his kingdom was transitory and very soon would be broken. David instead was anointed with the horn of power, thus the prophet in anticipation manifested the one who with divine power would demonstrate his victory over death.

Responsorial. *Act. 13: 32, 33; 2: 36*

R: What God promised our fathers he has fulfilled for us, their children, by raising Jesus from the dead, * as it is written: You are my Son, today I have generated you.

V: God has constituted this Jesus whom you crucified both Lord and Christ.

R: as it is written: You are my Son, today I have generated you.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 3: 1 – 20*

How to acquire wisdom.

A reading from the book of Proverbs.

My son, do not forget my teaching, but let your heart keep my commandments; for length of days and years of life and abundant welfare will they give you. Let not loyalty and faithfulness forsake you; bind them about your neck, write them on the tablet of your heart. So you will find favour and good repute in the sight of God and man.

Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not rely on your own insight. **In all your ways acknowledge him**, and **he will make straight your paths**. Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD, and turn away from evil. It will be healing to your flesh and refreshment to your bones.

Honour the LORD with your substance and with the first fruits of all your produce; then your barns will be filled with plenty, and your vats will be bursting with wine. My son, do not despise the LORD's discipline or be weary of his reproof, for the LORD reproves him whom he loves, as a father the son in whom he delights.

Happy is the man who finds wisdom, and the man who gets understanding, for the gain from it is better than gain from silver and its profit better than gold.

She is more precious than jewels, and nothing you desire can compare with her. Long life is in her right hand; in her left hand are riches and honour. Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace. She is a tree of life to those who lay hold of her; those who hold her fast are called happy. The LORD by wisdom founded the earth; by understanding

he established the heavens; by his knowledge the deeps broke forth, and the clouds drop down the dew.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Pr. 3:11, 12; Heb. 12: 7*

R: Do not refuse instruction from the Lord, do not be cast down when he punishes you. * The Lord corrects those whom he loves, like a father his beloved son.

V: God treats you like sons; and which son is not corrected by his father?

R: the Lord corrects those whom he loves, like a father his beloved son.

Second Reading. *De diversis 15*

Search for wisdom.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Bernard, abbot.

Let us work for the food that does not perish; let us do the work of our salvation. Let us work in the Lord’s vineyard so that we may deserve to receive our daily penny. Let us work in Wisdom who says, ‘Those who work with my help will not sin’. ‘The field is the world’, said the Truth, let us dig in it; a treasure lies hidden, let us dig it up. It is Wisdom herself who is drawn out from the hidden places. We all seek her, we all long for her.

‘If you will inquire’, he says, ‘inquire; turn and come back’. Do you ask what you are to turn back from? He replies, ‘Turn back from your appetites’. But, you say, if I cannot find Wisdom in my own appetites where do I find it? My soul longs passionately for Wisdom, and if I did happen to find her, it would not be enough just to find her unless I could put into my lap a good measure, pressed down, shaken together, running over. And rightly so. For, ‘happy is the man who finds Wisdom and is rich in understanding’. Seek her, therefore, whilst she may be found, and call on her whilst she is near. Do you want to know how near she is? ‘The word is near to you, on your lips and in your heart’, but only if you seek it with a true heart. Then you will find Wisdom with your heart and from your lips will pour forth understanding.

You have indeed found honey if you have found Wisdom, only do not eat too much lest you gorge yourself and become ill. So eat, as to be always hungry. For Wisdom herself says, ‘Those who eat me will hunger for more’. Do not set too great a store on what you have, do not gorge yourself lest you

vomit and what you seemed to have is taken away from you because you gave up the search too soon. Not even whilst Wisdom may be found, whilst she is near, should we give up searching and calling on her. Otherwise just as, in the words of Solomon, 'It is not good to eat much honey', so 'he who pries into majesty will be overwhelmed by its glory'.

It is a true saying, 'happy is the man who finds Wisdom', and it is even truer to say, 'happy', or rather, more happy 'is the man' who dwells with her. Perhaps this is what is meant by pouring forth.

Clearly, you pour forth wisdom or understanding from your lips in three ways: if on your lips there is the admission of your own sinfulness, thanksgiving and the voice of praise, and words that encourage. For indeed, 'a man believes with his heart and so is justified, and he confesses with his lips and so is saved'. And 'at the beginning of his speech the righteous man is his own accuser'; and in the middle of his words he gives praise to God, and in the third place, if so far wisdom has poured forth, he must also encourage his neighbour.

Responsorial. *Wis. 7: 10, 11; 8: 2*

R: I loved Wisdom more than health or beauty; I preferred her to the light of day; * all good things came to me together with her.

V: Wisdom I loved; I sought her out when I was young, and I fell in love with her beauty;

R: all good things came to me together with her.

Gospel. *Mt. 9: 18 – 26*

My daughter has just died; but come and she will live.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

While he was thus speaking to them, behold, a ruler came in and knelt before him, saying, "My daughter has just died; but come and lay your hand on her, and she will live."

And Jesus rose and followed him, with his disciples. And behold, a woman who had suffered from a haemorrhage for twelve years came up behind him and touched the fringe of his garment; for she said to herself, "If I only touch his garment, I shall be made well." Jesus turned, and seeing her he said, "Take heart, daughter; your faith has made you well." And instantly the woman was made well.

And when Jesus came to the ruler's house, and saw the flute players, and the crowd making a tumult, he said, "Depart; for the girl is not dead but sleeping." And they laughed at him. But when the crowd had been put outside, he went in and took her by the hand, and the girl arose. And the report of this went through all that district.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 19: 8 – 10; 20: 1 – 17*

Friendship between David and Jonathan.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

And there was war again; and David went out and fought with the Philistines, and made a great slaughter among them, so that they fled before him. Then an evil spirit from the LORD came upon Saul, as he sat in his house with his spear in his hand; and David was playing the lyre. And Saul sought to pin David to the wall with the spear; but he eluded Saul, so that he struck the spear into the wall. And David fled, and escaped.

Then David fled from Nai'oth in Ramah, and came and said before Jonathan, "What have I done? What is my guilt? And what is my sin before your father, that he seeks my life?" And he said to him, "Far from it! You shall not die. Behold, my father does nothing either great or small without disclosing it to me; and why should my father hide this from me? It is not so." But David replied, "Your father knows well that I have found favour in your eyes; and he thinks, 'Let not Jonathan know this, lest he be grieved.' But truly, as the LORD lives and as your soul lives, there is but a step between me and death." Then said Jonathan to David, "Whatever you say, I will do for you." David said to Jonathan, "Behold, tomorrow is the new moon, and I should not fail to sit at table with the king; but let me go, that I may hide myself in the field till the third day at evening. If your father misses me at all, then say, 'David earnestly asked leave of me to run to Bethlehem his city; for there is a yearly sacrifice there for all the family.' If he says, 'Good!' it will be well with your servant; but if he is angry, then know that evil is determined by him. Therefore deal kindly with your servant, for you have brought your servant into a sacred covenant with you. But if there is guilt in me, slay me yourself; for why should you bring me to your father?" And Jonathan said, "Far be it from you! If I knew that it was determined by my father that evil should come upon you, would I not tell you?" Then said David to Jonathan, "Who will tell me if your father answers you roughly?" And Jonathan said to David, "Come, let us go out into the field." So they both went out into the field.

And Jonathan said to David, "The LORD, the God of Israel, be witness! When I have sounded my father, about this time tomorrow, or the third day, behold, if he is well disposed toward David, shall I not then send and disclose it to you? But should it please my father to do you harm, the LORD do so to Jonathan, and more also, if I do not disclose it to you, and send you away, that you may go in safety. May the LORD be with you, as he has been with my father. If I am still alive, show me the loyal love of the LORD, that I may not die; and do not cut off your loyalty from my house forever. When the LORD cuts off every one of the enemies of David from the face of the earth, let not the name of Jonathan be cut off from the house of David. And may the LORD take vengeance on David's enemies." And Jonathan made David swear again by his love for him; for he loved him as he loved his own soul.

Responsorial. *cfr. Prv. 17: 17; 1 Jn. 4: 7*

R: A true friend always loves: * in misfortune he shows himself a brother.

V: Whoever loves, is generated by God and knows God,

R: in misfortune he shows himself a brother.

Second Reading. *Book 3*

The true, perfect and eternal friendship.

A reading from the treatise "On spiritual friendship" of St. Aelred, abbot.

Jonathan, that most excellent young man, made a pact with David, but not in the hope of obtaining the royal crown or in expectation of the kingdom. Making the servant equal to the master in friendship, he placed above himself the man who had been driven out by his father, who was hiding in the desert, condemned to death, marked out for execution. He humbled himself and exalted David. 'You shall be king', he said, 'and I shall be next to you'.

What a marvellous example of real friendship! What a wonderful thing! The king was raging against his servant and stirring up the whole country as though against a rival for the kingdom. Out of mere suspicion he massacred priests, accusing them of treachery. He searched the forests, spied out the valleys, posted armed bands on the mountains and cliffs. All swore that they would avenge the king's anger. Only Jonathan, who alone

had the right to be envious, thought it right to resist his father, to give his friend news, to offer him advice in his great adversity, and preferring friendship to the kingdom he said: 'You shall be king, and I shall be next to you'. Notice how the father tried to excite the envy of the young man against his friend, attacking him with insults, threatening to dispossess him of the kingdom, reminding him that he would be deprived of honour.

Even when Saul had issued the death sentence against David, Jonathan did not fail his friend. 'Why should David be put to death? What wrong has he done? He took his life in his hands and struck down the Philistine, and you rejoiced. Why, therefore, should he be put to death?' At these words the king was driven mad. He sought to pin Jonathan to the wall with his spear, adding insults to his threats: 'You son of a perverse, rebellious woman', he said, 'Do I not know that you love him to your own shame and to the shame of your wanton mother?' Then he poured out all his venom on the young man, adding a word to stimulate ambition and stir up envy, bigotry and jealousy: 'As long as the son of Jesse lives, your kingdom shall not be established'.

Who would not be moved and made envious by these words? Whose love, whose esteem, whose friendship would they not corrupt, lessen and destroy? But that most devoted young man, keeping the oaths of friendship, was strong in the face of threats, patient before insults. Because of his friendship he despised the kingship and forgot the glory, but remembered the love. 'You shall be king', he said, 'and I shall be next to you'.

This is true, perfect, enduring and eternal friendship that envy does not corrupt, nor suspicions lessen nor ambition dissolve. When thus put to the test it does not cease, thus assailed it does not fall in ruins. Although a prey to so much abuse, it is seen to be unyielding and remains unmoved when attacked by so many insults. Go, therefore, and do likewise.

Responsorial. *Sir. 6: 14, 17*

R: A faithful friend is a sure protection; * whoever finds one has found a rare treasure.

V: Whoever fears the Lord makes true friends, for as a man is, so is his friend;

R: Whoever finds one has found a rare treasure.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 8: 1 – 5, 12 – 36*

Eulogy of the creative Wisdom.

A reading from the book of Proverbs.

Does not wisdom call, does not understanding raise her voice? On the heights beside the way, in the paths she takes her stand; beside the gates in front of the town, at the entrance of the portals she cries aloud: "To you, O men, I call, and my cry is to the sons of men.

O simple ones, learn prudence; O foolish men, pay attention. I, wisdom, dwell in prudence, and I find knowledge and discretion. **The fear of the LORD is hatred of evil.** Pride and arrogance and the way of evil and perverted speech I hate. I have counsel and sound wisdom, I have insight, I have strength. By me kings reign, and rulers decree what is just; by me princes rule, and nobles govern the earth. I love those who love me, and those who seek me diligently find me.

Riches and honour are with me, enduring wealth and prosperity. My fruit is better than gold, even fine gold, and my yield than choice silver. I walk in the way of righteousness, in the paths of justice, endowing with wealth those who love me, and filling their treasuries.

The LORD created me at the beginning of his work, the first of his acts of old. Ages ago I was set up, at the first, before the beginning of the earth. When there were no depths I was brought forth, when there were no springs abounding with water. Before the mountains had been shaped, before the hills, I was brought forth; before he had made the earth with its fields, or the first of the dust of the world. When he established the heavens, I was there, when he drew a circle on the face of the deep, when he made firm the skies above, when he established the fountains of the deep, when he assigned to the sea its limit, so that the waters might not transgress his command, when he marked out the foundations of the earth, then I was beside him, like a master workman; and I was daily his delight, rejoicing before him always, rejoicing in his inhabited world and delighting in the sons of men.

And now, my sons, listen to me: happy are those who keep my ways. Hear instruction and be wise, and do not neglect it. Happy is the man who listens to me, watching daily at my gates, waiting beside my doors. For he

who finds me finds life and obtains favour from the LORD; but he who misses me injures himself; all who hate me love death."

Responsorial. *Pr. 8: 22; Jn. 1: 1*

R: The Lord had me with him at the beginning of his activity, * before all his works, from the beginning.

V: In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God and the Word was God,

R: before all his works, from the beginning.

Second Reading. *Disc. 2: 78, 81 – 82*

The knowledge of the Father comes to us through the creative and incarnate Wisdom.

A reading from the “Discourses against the Arians” of St. Athanasius, bishop.

Now the Only-begotten and very Wisdom of God is Creator and Framer of all things; for ‘in Wisdom have You made them all,’ he says, and ‘the earth is full of Your creation.’ But that what came into being might not only be, but be good, it pleased God that His own Wisdom should condescend to the creatures, so as to introduce an impress and semblance of Its Image on all in common and on each, that it might be manifested that the created things were adorned by Wisdom, and that the works that were constructed were worthy of God.

For as of the Son of God, considered as the Word, our word is an image, so of the same Son considered as Wisdom is the wisdom which is implanted in us an image; in which wisdom we, having the power of knowledge and thought, become recipients of the All-framing Wisdom; and through It we are able to know Its Father. ‘For he who has the Son,’ said He, ‘has the Father also;’ and ‘he who receives Me, receives the One who sent Me.’ Such an impress then of Wisdom being created in us, and being in all the works, with reason does the true and framing Wisdom take to Itself what belongs to its own impress, and say, ‘The Lord created me for His works;’

But “since in the wise design of God” as we have explained, “the world with all its wisdom has not known God, it pleased God to save the believers through the foolishness of the preaching” (1 Cor. 1: 21). God did not want

to be known anymore as in the past times, through the image and shadow of wisdom. He wanted that the same true Wisdom assumed flesh, became man and bore the death of the cross, so that through faith, which was founded in her, all the believers could be saved anew.

The Wisdom of God manifested itself and the Father, through its own image impressed in the created things. For this fact it is said that he was created. Later, that same Wisdom, who is the Word, became flesh, as St. John affirms. Destroying death and liberating the human race, he manifested himself more clearly and, through himself, the Father; whence these words of his: "That they may know you, the one true God, and he whom you have sent, Jesus Christ" (Jn. 17: 3).

Therefore the entire earth is full of his knowledge. Because one only is the knowledge of the Father through the Son and of the Son on the part of the Father. Of the same joy with which the Father is pleased, the Son also rejoices in the Father, as it results from this expression: I was the one in whom he was well pleased. Every day I delighted in his presence (Pr. 8: 30).

Responsorial. *Cfr. Col. 2: 6, 9; Mt. 23: 10*

R: Walk in the Lord Jesus Christ, as you have received him. * In him the fullness of God lives bodily.

V: One only is your Master, the Christ.

R: In him the fullness of God lives bodily.

Gospel. *Mt. 9: 32 – 38*

The harvest is great, but the labourers are few.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

As they were going away, behold, a dumb demoniac was brought to him. And when the demon had been cast out, the dumb man spoke; and the crowds marvelled, saying, "Never was anything like this seen in Israel." But the Pharisees said, "He casts out demons by the prince of demons."

And Jesus went about all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues and preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every disease and every infirmity. When he saw the crowds, he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd. Then he said to his disciples, "The harvest is plentiful, but the

labourers are few; pray therefore the Lord of the harvest to send out labourers into his harvest."

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 21: 1 – 10; 22: 1 – 5*

The flight of David.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Then came David to Nob to Ahim'elech the priest; and Ahim'elech came to meet David trembling, and said to him, "Why are you alone, and no one with you?" And David said to Ahim'elech the priest, "The king has charged me with a matter, and said to me, 'Let no one know anything of the matter about which I send you, and with which I have charged you.' I have made an appointment with the young men for such and such a place. Now then, what have you at hand? Give me five loaves of bread, or whatever is here." And the priest answered David, "I have no common bread at hand, but there is holy bread; if only the young men have kept themselves from women." And David answered the priest, "Of a truth women have been kept from us as always when I go on an expedition; the vessels of the young men are holy, even when it is a common journey; how much more today will their vessels be holy?" So the priest gave him the holy bread; for there was no bread there but the bread of the Presence, which is removed from before the LORD, to be replaced by hot bread on the day it is taken away. Now a certain man of the servants of Saul was there that day, detained before the LORD; his name was Do'eg the E'domite, the chief of Saul's herdsmen. And David said to Ahim'elech, "And have you not here a spear or a sword at hand? For I have brought neither my sword nor my weapons with me, because the king's business required haste." And the priest said, "The sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom you killed in the valley of Elah, behold, it is here wrapped in a cloth behind the ephod; if you will take that, take it, for there is none but that here." And David said, "There is none like that; give it to me."

And David rose and fled that day from Saul, and went to A'chish the king of Gath. David departed from there and escaped to the cave of Adullam; and when his brothers and all his father's house heard it, they went down there to him. And every one who was in distress, and every one

who was in debt, and every one who was discontented, gathered to him; and he became captain over them. And there were with him about four hundred men. And David went from there to Mizpeh of Moab; and he said to the king of Moab, "Pray let my father and my mother stay with you, till I know what God will do for me." And he left them with the king of Moab, and they stayed with him all the time that David was in the stronghold. Then the prophet Gad said to David, "Do not remain in the stronghold; depart, and go into the land of Judah." So David departed, and went into the forest of Hereth.

Responsorial. *cfr. Rm. 7: 6; Mk. 2: 25, 26*

R: We have been freed from the law of death that kept us prisoners. * We serve the Lord in the newness of the Spirit and not in the old regime of the letter.

V: Have you not read about what David did when he was hungry? How he entered into the house of God and ate the bread of the offering?

R: We serve the Lord in the newness of the Spirit and not in the old regime of the letter.

Second Reading. *Hom 6*

God is like an inaccessible rock.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

When from the sublime words of the Lord resembling the summit of a mountain I looked down into the ineffable depths of his thoughts, my mind had the experience of a man who gazes from a high ridge into the immense sea below him. On the coast one can often see some mountain whose front, facing the sea, is cut off straight from top to bottom, while its projecting upper part forms a peak overhanging the depth. Now if a man looked down from such a peak into the sea below, he would feel giddy. So also my soul does now, as it is raised from the ground by this great word of the Lord, 'Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God'. God is promised to the vision of those whose heart has been purified. But 'no man has seen God at any time', as says the great John. And the sublime mind of Paul confirms this verdict when he says, 'Whom no man has seen, nor can see'.

This is the slippery, steep rock that affords no basis for our thoughts, which the teaching of Moses, too, declared to be so inaccessible that our

mind can nowhere approach him. For all possibility of apprehension is taken away by this explicit denial, 'No man can see the Lord and live'. Yet to see the Lord is eternal life. On the other hand, those pillars of the faith, John and Paul and Moses, declare it to be impossible. Do you realize the vertigo of the soul that is drawn to the depths contemplated in these words?

If God is life, then the man who does not see him does not see life. On the other hand, the divinely inspired prophets and apostles testify that God cannot be seen. Is not the hope of man annihilated? Yet the Lord supports this faltering hope, as he did with Peter whom he put back on the water he had made solid, when he was in danger of sinking. If, therefore, the hand of the Word is stretched out also to us and confirms in a different view those who have lost their balance in the depths of their speculations, we may be without fear, as we are firmly held by the guiding hand of the Word. For he says, 'Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God'.

Responsorial. *Jn. 1: 18; Ps. 144: 3*

R: No one has ever seen God, * but God's only Son, who is nearest to the Father's heart, has made him known.

V: Can anyone measure the magnificence of the great Lord, and his inexpressible grandeur?

R: But God's only Son, who is nearest to the Father's heart, has made him known.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 9: 1 – 18*

Wisdom and foolishness.

A reading from the book of Proverbs.

Wisdom has built her house; she has set up her seven pillars. She has slaughtered her beasts, she has mixed her wine, she has also set her table. She has sent out her maids to call from the highest places in the town, "Whoever is simple, let him turn in here!" To him who is without sense she says, "Come, eat of my bread and drink of the wine I have mixed. Leave simpleness, and live, and walk in the way of insight."

He who corrects a scoffer gets himself abuse, and he who reproves a wicked man incurs injury. Do not reprove a scoffer, or he will hate you; reprove a wise man, and he will love you. Give instruction to a wise man, and he will be still wiser; teach a righteous man and he will increase in learning.

The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight. For I will multiply your days, and years will be added to your life.

If you are wise, you are wise for yourself; if you scoff, you alone will bear it.

A foolish woman is noisy; she is wanton and knows no shame. She sits at the door of her house, she takes a seat on the high places of the town, calling to those who pass by, who are going straight on their way, "Whoever is simple, let him turn in here!" And to him who is without sense she says, "Stolen water is sweet, and bread eaten in secret is pleasant."

But he does not know that the dead are there, that her guests are in the depths of Sheol.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Lk. 14: 16-17; Prv. 9: 5*

R: A man gave a great dinner, when the hour came, he sent his servant to say to those who were invited: * Come, everything is ready for you.

V: Come, eat my bread, drink the wine that I have prepared;

R: Come, everything is ready for you.

Second Reading. *C. 9*

The wisdom of God has prepared for us the table.

A reading from the "Commentary on the Book of Proverbs" of St. Procopius of Gaza, bishop.

‘Wisdom has built herself a house’. The personal, subsistent power of God the Father has built as his dwelling place not only the whole universe in which he lives by his activity, but also man whom he has made in his own image and likeness, with a nature partly seen, partly unseen.

‘She has set up her seven pillars’. To man thus created in Christ’s image after his birth, Wisdom gives the seven gifts of the Holy Spirit, in so far as he believes in Christ and keeps his commandments. If he lives by the Spirit, these gifts will bring him to perfection, if by their means his virtue is

motivated by his knowledge, and this knowledge itself is embodied in virtue. He will be made perfect by participating in the divine nature of faith, and by his sharing in supernatural things. The gifts of the Spirit direct aright the enlightenment in the spirit according to nature: fortitude which prepares him eagerly to rush forward and be moved to the reasons for things that are, namely the will of God according to which all things have come into being; counsel which discriminates between the all holy will of God, as being uncreated and indestructible and allowing thought and speech and action, and what is opposite to that will; understanding which makes a man turn towards these and not to their opposites and to agree with them.

‘She has mixed her wine in her chalice; she has laid her table’. Such a man is like a chalice in which a nature both spiritual and physical is mixed. In him God has united a recognition of himself as the cause of the universe, and a knowledge of his creatures. On the mind possessed of the knowledge it is natural for the things of God to have the inebriating effect of wine. So does he himself, the bread from heaven, become the nourishment of souls whereby they grow in virtue. He makes them drink in knowledge to their delight, and all this he has prepared as a heavenly banquet for the spiritual entertainment of those who wish to share it.

‘She has sent out her servants with the sublime invitation to receive the chalice’. Christ sent out the apostles as the ministers of his divine will. They were to proclaim that spiritual gospel which ranks above natural law and written codes, and to call men to himself. In him, as in a chalice, the mystery of the Incarnation effected without confusion that astounding hypostatic union of the divine and human natures. Through the apostles he says:

‘He who is foolish let him turn aside to me’. It is the man who thinks in his heart ‘There is no God’ who is foolish. Let him give up his disbelief and draw near to me through faith; then he will know that I am the creator of all things and their Lord.

‘And to those who lack wisdom he says: Come, eat my bread, and drink the wine I have mixed for you’. To those who are still deficient in the works of faith and in the more perfect knowledge of God that inspires them, he says: Come, eat my body, the bread that makes you grow according to virtue, and drink my blood, the wine that delights you according to knowledge and intoxicates you to become divine – the blood which I miraculously mingled with my divine nature for your salvation.

Responsorial. *Prv. 9: 1-2; Jn. 6: 56*

R: Wisdom has built herself a house, she has erected her seven pillars; *
Wisdom has prepared her wine and laid her table.

V: He who eats my flesh and drinks my blood lives in me and I live in him,
says the Lord.

R: Wisdom has prepared her wine and laid her table.

Gospel. *Mt. 10: 1 – 7*

Go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal every disease and every infirmity. The names of the twelve apostles are these: first, Simon, who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother; James the son of Zeb'edee, and John his brother; Philip and Bartholomew; Thomas and Matthew the tax collector; James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus; Simon the Cananaean, and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him.

These twelve Jesus sent out, charging them, "Go nowhere among the Gentiles, and enter no town of the Samaritans, but go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. And preach as you go, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.'

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 25: 14 – 24, 28 – 39*

David and Abigail.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

But one of the young men told Ab'igail, Nabal's wife, "Behold, David sent messengers out of the wilderness to salute our master; and he railed at them. Yet the men were very good to us, and we suffered no harm, and we did not miss anything when we were in the fields, as long as we went with them; they were a wall to us both by night and by day, all the while we were with them keeping the sheep. Now therefore know this and consider what you should do; for evil is determined against our master and against all his house, and he is so ill-natured that one cannot speak to him." Then Ab'igail made haste, and took two hundred loaves, and two skins of wine, and five sheep ready dressed, and five measures of parched grain, and a hundred clusters of raisins, and two hundred cakes of figs, and laid them on asses. And she said to her young men, "Go on before me; behold, I come after you." But she did not tell her husband Nabal.

And as she rode on the ass, and came down under cover of the mountain, behold, David and his men came down toward her; and she met them. Now David had said, "Surely in vain have I guarded all that this fellow has in the wilderness, so that nothing was missed of all that belonged to him; and he has returned me evil for good. God do so to David and more also, if by morning I leave so much as one male of all who belong to him." When Ab'igail saw David, she made haste, and alighted from the ass, and fell before David on her face, and bowed to the ground. She fell at his feet and said, "Upon me alone, my lord, be the guilt; pray let your handmaid speak in your ears, and hear the words of your handmaid. Pray forgive the trespass of your handmaid; for the LORD will certainly make my lord a sure house, because my lord is fighting the battles of the LORD; and evil shall not be found in you so long as you live. If men rise up to pursue you and to seek your life, the life of my lord shall be bound in the bundle of the living in the care of the LORD your God; and the lives of your enemies he shall sling out as from the hollow of a sling. And when the LORD has done

to my lord according to all the good that he has spoken concerning you, and has appointed you prince over Israel, my lord shall have no cause of grief, or pangs of conscience, for having shed blood without cause or for my lord taking vengeance himself. And when the LORD has dealt well with my lord, then remember your handmaid." And David said to Ab'igail, "Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who sent you this day to meet me! Blessed be your discretion, and blessed be you, who have kept me this day from bloodguilt and from avenging myself with my own hand! For as surely as the LORD the God of Israel lives, who has restrained me from hurting you, unless you had made haste and come to meet me, truly by morning there had not been left to Nabal so much as one male." Then David received from her hand what she had brought him; and he said to her, "Go up in peace to your house; see, I have hearkened to your voice, and I have granted your petition."

And Ab'igail came to Nabal; and, lo, he was holding a feast in his house, like the feast of a king. And Nabal's heart was merry within him, for he was very drunk; so she told him nothing at all until the morning light. And in the morning, when the wine had gone out of Nabal, his wife told him these things, and his heart died within him, and he became as a stone. And about ten days later the LORD smote Nabal; and he died. When David heard that Nabal was dead, he said, "Blessed be the LORD who has avenged the insult I received at the hand of Nabal, and has kept back his servant from evil; the LORD has returned the evil-doing of Nabal upon his own head." Then David sent and wooed Ab'igail, to make her his wife.

Responsorial. *1 Sam. 25: 33, 32; Mt. 5: 7*

R: You have impeded me today from shedding blood and doing justice by myself: * blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel who has sent you to meet me.

V: Blessed are the merciful, for they will find mercy.

R: Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel who has sent you to meet me.

Second Reading. *Hom.6*

The hope of seeing God.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

God's promise is so great that it transcends the utmost limits of beatitude. For what else could one desire after such a good, since he possesses all things in the one he contemplates? For according to scriptural use to see means the same as to have; for example, 'May you see the good things of Jerusalem' instead of 'May you find', which is the meaning of the passage; and 'Let the ungodly be taken away, that he may not see the glory of the Lord', where by not seeing the prophet indicates not participating in. Hence the man who sees God possesses in this act of seeing all there is of the things that are good. By this we understand life without end, eternal incorruptibility, undying beatitude. With these we shall enjoy the everlasting kingdom of unceasing happiness; we shall see the true light and hear the sweet voice of the Spirit; we shall exult perpetually in all that is good in the inaccessible glory.

So magnificent a consummation is offered to our hope in the promise made in this Beatitude. But since, as has been shown before, the seeing has been made dependent on purity of heart, my mind once more grows dizzy, lest perhaps purity of heart should be impossible to achieve because it surpasses our nature. For if the vision of God depends on this, if, on the other hand Moses and Paul did not see him – and it is stated that neither he nor anyone else can see him – the Word now seems to propose something impossible in this Beatitude. What, therefore, do we gain from knowing how one sees God, if the mind finds it impossible to do so? It would be just as if one said that it is blessed to be in heaven, because there one contemplates what cannot be seen in this life. Now if this statement also showed a means of journeying to heaven, it would indeed be profitable to the hearers to learn that it is blessed to be there. But as long as the ascent is impossible, what use is it to know about the heavenly beatitude? It only saddens those who have learned about it to realize of what things we are deprived, because the ascent is not feasible.

Yet should the Lord command something so great that it completely surpasses our nature and the limits of its power? Surely not. He does not tell those he had not provided with wings to become birds, nor does he bid creatures he has destined to sojourn on land to live in the water. The law is adapted to the capacities of those that receive it in everything else, and nothing is enforced that is beyond nature. Hence we shall realize that neither does this Beatitude set forth what outstrips hope. Nor have John, Paul, Moses, and others like them been lacking in the transcendent

beatitude that consists in seeing God. No; for the one said: 'There is laid up for me a crown of justice, which the Lord the just Judge will render to me'; the other lay upon the breast of Jesus; and the third heard the divine voice say, 'I have known you above all'.

Now it cannot be doubted that those who have proclaimed the perception of God to be above human power are themselves blessed. On the other hand, **beatitude consists in seeing God, and this depends on being pure of heart**. Hence surely the purity of heart through which we may become blessed **cannot be impossible**. How is it then that the voice of the Lord, which promises that God may be seen if we are pure, should not contradict those who, according to Saint Paul, evidently speak the truth if they contend that the contemplation of God is beyond our power?

Responsorial. *Ps. 62: 2; 16: 15*

R: For you my soul is thirsting; * My flesh faints for you, O God, my God.

V: In my justice I shall see your face, and be filled, when I awake, with the sight of your glory;

R: My flesh faints for you, O God, my God.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 10:6 – 32*

Various sentences.

Blessings are on the head of the righteous, but the mouth of the wicked conceals violence. The memory of the righteous is a blessing, but the name of the wicked will rot. The wise of heart will heed commandments, but **a prattling fool will come to ruin**.

He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out. He who winks the eye causes trouble, but he who boldly reproves makes peace. The mouth of the righteous is a fountain of life, but the mouth of the wicked conceals violence. Hatred stirs up strife, but love covers all offences. On the lips of him who has understanding wisdom is found, but a rod is for the back of him who lacks sense. Wise men lay up knowledge, but the babbling of a fool brings ruin near.

A rich man's wealth is his strong city; the poverty of the poor is their ruin. The wage of the righteous leads to life, the gain of the wicked to sin. He who heeds instruction is on the path to life, but he who rejects reproof goes astray.

He who conceals hatred has lying lips, and he who utters slander is a fool. When words are many, transgression is not lacking, but he who restrains his lips is prudent. The tongue of the righteous is choice silver; the mind of the wicked is of little worth.

The lips of the righteous feed many, but fools die for lack of sense. The blessing of the LORD makes rich, and he adds no sorrow with it.

It is like sport to a fool to do wrong, but wise conduct is pleasure to a man of understanding. What the wicked dreads will come upon him, but the desire of the righteous will be granted. When the tempest passes, the wicked is no more, but the righteous is established forever. Like vinegar to the teeth, and smoke to the eyes, so is the sluggard to those who send him.

The fear of the LORD prolongs life, but the years of the wicked will be short. The hope of the righteous ends in gladness, but the expectation of the wicked comes to nought. The LORD is a stronghold to him whose way is upright, but destruction to evildoers. The righteous will never be removed, but the wicked will not dwell in the land. The mouth of the righteous brings forth wisdom, but the perverse tongue will be cut off. The lips of the righteous know what is acceptable, but the mouth of the wicked, what is perverse.

Responsorial. *Ps. 36: 30-31; 111: 6, 7*

R: The mouth of the just man proclaims wisdom and his tongue expresses justice; * the law of his God is in his heart.

V: The just man will always be remembered; he will not fear announcements of misfortune;

R: the law of his God is in his heart

Second Reading. *Ps. 36: 65 – 66*

Open your mouth to the word of God.

A reading from the “Commentary on the psalms” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

Let us be for ever pondering on wisdom in our hearts and discussing it with our lips; **let your tongue speak only what is right**, and let **God's law be constantly in your hearts**. For that is what scripture enjoins on us: 'let your concern be only with such things as these when you sit in your house and walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise'. Let the Lord Jesus then be the sole object of your discourse, for he is Wisdom, even the Word, God's own word. For scripture also commands, 'Open your mouth to receive God's word'. That man manifests him who constantly repeats his sayings and meditates on his words. Let us always be speaking of him. Whenever we speak of wisdom it is of him we speak; when we speak of virtue it is of him we speak; and when we speak of truth and life and redemption it is of him.

It is written, 'Open your mouth to the word of God'. It is for you to open, but he speaks. Therefore David said, 'I will hear what the Lord says within me', and the Son of God himself says, 'Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it'. But not all of us can receive, like Solomon and Daniel, the perfection of wisdom, but upon all will be poured out the Spirit of wisdom to each according to his capacity, provided that he is a man of faith. If you believe, you have the spirit of wisdom.

Therefore 'when you sit in your house' meditate and speak always of the things of God. 'House' we can take to mean the Church or our own interior house where we may speak within ourselves. **Choose your words when you speak so that you avoid sin and do not fall through empty chatter**. When you are seated **speak to yourself as one who is a judge**. When you are 'by the way' speak lest you be idle. You speak 'by the way' if you speak in Christ, for Christ is the way. Speak to yourself 'by the way' and you speak to Christ. Hear then how you are to talk to him, 'I desire', he says, 'that in every place the men should pray, lifting holy hands without anger or quarrelling'. Speak, O man, when you are falling asleep lest the sleep of death overtake you. Hear how you should speak as you go to sleep, 'I will not give sleep to my eyes or slumber to my eyelids, until I find a place for the Lord, a dwelling for the mighty one of Jacob'.

In your rising or resurrection speak of him that you may carry out what you are commanded to do. Hear how Christ wakens you. Your soul says, 'The voice of my brother sounds at the gate', and Christ says, 'Open to me, my sister, my spouse'. And hear how you are to waken Christ. The soul

says, 'I have adjured you, O daughters of Jerusalem, to waken and re-awaken love'. Love is Christ.

Responsorial *1 Cor. 1: 30-31; Jn. 1: 16*

R: God gave us all Christ Jesus to be our wisdom, our justification, our sanctification and our atonement, * so that the scripture might be fulfilled, If anyone boasts, let him make his boast in the Lord.

V: We have all received something out of his abundance, grace answering to grace,

R: so that the scripture might be fulfilled, If anyone boasts, let him make his boast in the Lord.

Gospel. *Mt. 10: 7 – 15*

Jesus said to them: And preach as you go, saying, 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand.' Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You received without paying, give without pay. Take no gold, nor silver, nor copper in your belts, no bag for your journey, nor two tunics, nor sandals, nor a staff; for the labourer deserves his food. And whatever town or village you enter, find out who is worthy in it, and stay with him until you depart. As you enter the house, salute it. And if the house is worthy, let your peace come upon it; but if it is not worthy, let your peace return to you. And if any one will not receive you or listen to your words, shake off the dust from your feet as you leave that house or town. Truly, I say to you, it shall be more tolerable on the Day of Judgment for the land of Sodom and Gomor'rah than for that town.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 26: 5 – 25*

David shows himself magnanimous towards Saul.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Then David rose and came to the place where Saul had encamped; and David saw the place where Saul lay, with Abner the son of Ner, the commander of his army; Saul was lying within the encampment, while the army was encamped around him. Then David said to Ahim'elech the Hittite, and to Jo'ab's brother Abi'shai the son of Zeru'iah, "Who will go down with me into the camp to Saul?" And Abi'shai said, "I will go down with you." So David and Abi'shai went to the army by night; and there lay Saul sleeping within the encampment, with his spear stuck in the ground at his head; and Abner and the army lay around him. Then said Abi'shai to David, "God has given your enemy into your hand this day; now therefore let me pin him to the earth with one stroke of the spear, and I will not strike him twice." But David said to Abi'shai, "Do not destroy him; for who can put forth his hand against the LORD'S anointed, and be guiltless?" And David said, "As the LORD lives, the LORD will smite him; or his day shall come to die; or he shall go down into battle and perish. The LORD forbid that I should put forth my hand against the LORD'S anointed; but take now the spear that is at his head, and the jar of water, and let us go." So David took the spear and the jar of water from Saul's head; and they went away. No man saw it, or knew it, nor did any awake; for they were all asleep, because a deep sleep from the LORD had fallen upon them.

Then David went over to the other side, and stood afar off on the top of the mountain, with a great space between them; and David called to the army, and to Abner the son of Ner, saying, "Will you not answer, Abner?" Then Abner answered, "Who are you that calls to the king?" And David said to Abner, "Are you not a man? Who is like you in Israel? Why then have you not kept watch over your lord the king? For one of the people came in to destroy the king your lord. This thing that you have done is not good. As the LORD lives, you deserve to die, because you have not kept watch over your lord, the LORD'S anointed. And now see where the king's

spear is, and the jar of water that was at his head." Saul recognized David's voice, and said, "Is this your voice, my son David?" And David said, "It is my voice, my lord, O king." and he said, "Why does my lord pursue after his servant? For what have I done? What guilt is on my hands? Now therefore let my lord the king hear the words of his servant. If it is the LORD who has stirred you up against me, may he accept an offering; but if it is men, may they be cursed before the LORD, for they have driven me out this day that I should have no share in the heritage of the LORD, saying, 'Go, serve other gods.' Now therefore, let not my blood fall to the earth away from the presence of the LORD; for the king of Israel has come out to seek my life, like one who hunts a partridge in the mountains." Then Saul said, "I have done wrong; return, my son David, for I will no more do you harm, because my life was precious in your eyes this day; behold, I have played the fool, and have erred exceedingly." And David made answer, "Here is the spear, O king! Let one of the young men come over and fetch it. The LORD rewards every man for his righteousness and his faithfulness; for the LORD gave you into my hand today, and I would not put forth my hand against the LORD'S anointed. Behold, as your life was precious this day in my sight, so may my life be precious in the sight of the LORD, and may he deliver me out of all tribulation." Then Saul said to David, "Blessed be you, my son David! You will do many things and will succeed in them." So David went his way, and Saul returned to his place.

Responsorial. *Ps. 53: 5, 3, 8, 4*

R: The arrogant have risen against me; the overbearing threaten me; God, save me for the sake of your name, * by your power give me justice.

V: With all my heart I offer you a sacrifice; God, listen to my prayer,

R: by your power give me justice.

Second Reading. *Hom. 6*

God can be found in the heart of man.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Bodily health is one of the desirable things in human life; but it is blessed not only to know the principle of health, but to be healthy. For supposing someone had sung the praises of health, yet took some unwholesome food that generated bad juices- what use is it to him to have

praised health, seeing that he is afflicted with diseases? In the same way, therefore, we should understand the words we are considering. The Lord does not say it is blessed to know something about God, but to have God present within oneself. 'Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God'. I do not think that if the eye of one's soul has been purified, he is promised a direct vision of God; but perhaps this marvellous saying may suggest what the Word expresses more clearly when he says to the others, 'The kingdom of God is within you'. By this we should learn that if a man's heart has been purified from every creature and all unruly affections, he will see the image of the divine nature in his own beauty. I think that in this short saying the Word expresses some such counsel as this: There is in you, human beings, a desire to contemplate the true good. But when you hear that the divine majesty is exalted above the heavens, that its glory is inexpressible, its beauty ineffable, and its nature inaccessible, do not despair of ever beholding what you desire. It is indeed within your reach; you have within yourselves the standard by which to apprehend the divine. For he who made you did at the same time endow your nature with this wonderful quality. For God imprinted on it the likeness of the glories of his own nature, as if moulding the form of a carving into wax. But the evil that has been poured all around the nature bearing the divine image has rendered useless to you this wonderful thing, which lies hidden under vile coverings. If, therefore, you wash off by a good life the filth that has been stuck on your heart like plaster, the divine beauty will again shine forth in you.

It is the same as happens in the case of iron. If freed from rust by a whetstone, that which a moment ago was black will shine and glisten brightly in the sun. So it is also with the inner man, which the Lord calls the heart. When he has scraped off the rust like dirt which dank decay has caused to appear on his form, he will once more recover the likeness of the archetype and be good. For what is like to the good is certainly itself good. Hence, if a man who is pure of heart sees himself, he sees in himself what he desires; and thus he becomes blessed, because when he looks at his own purity, he sees the archetype in the image.

To give an example. Though men who see the sun in a mirror do not gaze at the sky itself, yet they see the sun in the reflection of the mirror no less than those who look at its very orb. So, he says, it is also with you. Even though you are too weak, to perceive the light itself, yet, if you but return to the grace of the image with which you were formed from the

beginning, you will have all you seek in yourselves. For the godhead is purity, freedom from passion, and separation from all evil. If therefore these things be in you, God is indeed in you. Hence, if your thought is without any alloy of evil, free from passion, and alien from all stain, you are blessed because you are clear of sight. You are able to perceive what is invisible to those who are not purified, because you have been cleansed; the darkness caused by material entanglements has been removed from the eyes of your soul, and so you see the blessed vision radiant in the pure heaven of your heart. But what is this vision? It is purity, sanctity, simplicity, and other such luminous reflections of the divine nature, in which God is contemplated.

Responsorial. *Jn. 14: 6, 9; 6: 47*

R: Thus says the Lord: I am the Way, the Truth and the Life. * To have seen me is to have seen the Father.

V: He who believes in me has eternal life.

R: To have seen me is to have seen the Father.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 15: 8 – 9, 16 – 17, 25 – 26, 29, 33; 16: 1 – 9; 17:5*

Man placed in front of God.

A reading from the book of Proverbs.

The sacrifice of the wicked is an abomination to the LORD, but the prayer of the upright is his delight. The way of the wicked is an abomination to the LORD, but he loves him who pursues righteousness. Better is a little with the fear of the LORD than great treasure and trouble with it. Better is a dinner of herbs where love is than a fatted ox and hatred with it.

The LORD tears down the house of the proud, but maintains the widow's boundaries. The thoughts of the wicked are an abomination to the LORD, the words of the pure are pleasing to him. The LORD is far from the wicked, but he hears the prayer of the righteous. The fear of the LORD is instruction in wisdom, and humility goes before honour.

The plans of the mind belong to man, but the answer of the tongue is from the LORD. All the ways of a man are pure in his own eyes, but the

LORD weighs the spirit. Commit your work to the LORD, and your plans will be established. The LORD has made everything for its purpose, even the wicked for the day of trouble. Every one who is arrogant is an abomination to the LORD; be assured, he will not go unpunished.

By loyalty and faithfulness iniquity is atoned for, and **by the fear of the LORD a man avoids evil**. When a man's ways please the LORD, he makes even his enemies to be at peace with him.

Better is a little with righteousness than great revenues with injustice. A man's mind plans his way, but the LORD directs his steps. He who mocks the poor insults his Maker; he who is glad at calamity will not go unpunished.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Deut. 6: 12, 13; Prv. 15: 33*

R: Do not forget the Lord, who has made you come out from Egypt: * you will fear the Lord your God and serve him.

V: The fear of God is the school of wisdom; humility precedes glory.

R: You will fear the Lord your God and serve him.

Second Reading. *Patericon, 142b*

Consider yourselves sinners if you want to become just.

A reading from the “Sentences of the Fathers” of John Mosco, monk.

Wisdom says: he who hides his own faults will not have salvation (cfr. Prv. 28: 13); the Lord instead will have mercy on the one who recognizes his sin and does penance. Bear evil and this will be a disgrace in front of the world. But the heart of the Lord is against the proud, in order to humiliate them. Humility receives an eternal mercy. Make yourselves small in all human works, and he will raise you up above the great men of the world; let your behaviour be humble in front of everyone and greet everyone first, as important people. **He who feels himself on high because of his knowledge is small in front of men, even if he is wise and intelligent, he is wise only for himself, for that which he discovers.** Blessed is he who lends himself in every deed, because he will be exalted above everyone. He who becomes humble for the Lord and lowers himself in front of him, will be praised by the Lord; and he who suffers hunger and thirst for the Lord, will be filled with good things by the Lord; he who offers consolation for him, will be

clothed with glory by him; he who is poor and suffers for him, will be consoled by him with the true riches.

Despise your life for the Lord, and your praise will spread even without you knowing it for all the days of your life. Consider yourself a sinner in order to be just. Be humble in your knowledge, so that it may not puff you up. Associate with the good, in order to draw near to the Lord through them. Remain with the humble in order to learn their way of living.

The monk must have his heart prepared for the heavenly realities, and he must always be without sadness in his thoughts. He who sows among the thorns cannot reap: so also he who follows the desire of excelling, of accumulating, and of all the other wicked deeds loses his own soul. The Lord looks on the humble. The prayer of the humble runs from the mouth to his ears. The spirit of service and humility makes man a God on earth. Faith and mercy very soon bring wisdom with themselves.

Blessed are those who immerse themselves in tribulations without anger and bitterness, for love of the Lord; as soon as these draw away from them, they are saved in the port of divinity and reach the house of the Lord doing good. Here they have rest from their troubles and enjoy the fruit of hope. Those who run in hope are not frightened by the tribulations of the way nor do they stop searching for it; then when they come out from the sea, they contemplate and praise the Lord who has saved them from perdition and from many unknown difficulties, because they have not offered themselves to admiration.

It is better for us to die for the Lord than to live in disgrace and in weakness. Remember always that which will follow death, and weakness will never enter into your soul. Choose to do good for the Lord and you will draw near to him. Do not go together with the one who is double hearted, run along the way hoping in the grace of the Lord so that your efforts will not be useless.

Have in your heart the firm certainty that the Lord is merciful and that to those who search for him he will give his grace not according to our actions, but according to the love of our heart and our faith, as Scripture says: "Let it be done according to your faith" (Mt. 8: 13).

Responsorial. *Rm. 11: 20, 21; 1 Cor. 4: 7*

R: You stand by faith. * Do not be arrogant, but be afraid. For if God did not spare the natural branches, he will not spare you either.

V: Who therefore has given you this privilege? What do you possess that you have not received?

R: Do not be arrogant, but be afraid. For if God did not spare the natural branches, he will not spare you either.

Gospel. Mt. 10: 16 – 23

It will not be you who will speak, but the Spirit of your Father.

A reading from the Gospel of St, Matthew.

"Behold, I send you out as sheep in the midst of wolves; so be wise as serpents and innocent as doves. Beware of men; for they will deliver you up to councils, and flog you in their synagogues, and you will be dragged before governors and kings for my sake, to bear testimony before them and the Gentiles. When they deliver you up, do not be anxious how you are to speak or what you are to say; for what you are to say will be given to you in that hour; for it is not you who speak, but the Spirit of your Father speaking through you. Brother will deliver up brother to death, and the father his child, and children will rise against parents and have them put to death; and you will be hated by all for my name's sake. But he who endures to the end will be saved. When they persecute you in one town, flee to the next; for truly, I say to you, you will not have gone through all the towns of Israel, before the Son of man comes.

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 28: 3 – 25*

Saul goes to the medium at Endor.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Now Samuel had died, and all Israel had mourned for him and buried him in Ramah, his own city. And Saul had put the mediums and the wizards out of the land.

The Philistines assembled, and came and encamped at Shunem; and Saul gathered all Israel, and they encamped at Gilbo'a. When Saul saw the army of the Philistines, he was afraid, and his heart trembled greatly. And when Saul inquired of the LORD, the LORD did not answer him, either by dreams, or by Urim, or by prophets. Then Saul said to his servants, "Seek out for me a woman who is a medium, that I may go to her and inquire of her." And his servants said to him, "Behold, there is a medium at Endor." So Saul disguised himself and put on other garments, and went, he and two men with him; and they came to the woman by night. And he said, "Divine for me by a spirit, and bring up for me whomever I shall name to you." The woman said to him, "Surely you know what Saul has done, how he has cut off the mediums and the wizards from the land. Why then are you laying a snare for my life to bring about my death?" But Saul swore to her by the LORD, "As the LORD lives, no punishment shall come upon you for this thing." Then the woman said, "Whom shall I bring up for you?" He said, "Bring up Samuel for me."

When the woman saw Samuel, she cried out with a loud voice; and the woman said to Saul, "Why have you deceived me? You are Saul." The king said to her, "Have no fear; what do you see?" And the woman said to Saul, "I see a god coming up out of the earth." He said to her, "What is his appearance?" And she said, "An old man is coming up; and he is wrapped in a robe." And Saul knew that it was Samuel, and he bowed with his face to the ground, and did obeisance. Then Samuel said to Saul, "Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?" Saul answered, "I am in great distress; for the Philistines are warring against me, and God has turned away from me and answers me no more, either by prophets or by dreams; therefore I

have summoned you to tell me what I shall do." And Samuel said, "Why then do you ask me, since the LORD has turned from you and become your enemy? The LORD has done to you as he spoke by me; for the LORD has torn the kingdom out of your hand, and given it to your neighbour, David. Because you did not obey the voice of the LORD, and did not carry out his fierce wrath against Amalek, therefore the LORD has done this thing to you this day. Moreover the LORD will give Israel also with you into the hand of the Philistines; and tomorrow you and your sons shall be with me; the LORD will give the army of Israel also into the hand of the Philistines." Then Saul fell at once full length upon the ground, filled with fear because of the words of Samuel; and there was no strength in him, for he had eaten nothing all day and all night. And the woman came to Saul, and when she saw that he was terrified, she said to him, "Behold, your handmaid has hearkened to you; I have taken my life in my hand, and have hearkened to what you have said to me. Now therefore, you also hearken to your handmaid; let me set a morsel of bread before you; and eat, that you may have strength when you go on your way." He refused, and said, "I will not eat." But his servants, together with the woman, urged him; and he hearkened to their words. So he arose from the earth, and sat upon the bed. Now the woman had a fatted calf in the house, and she quickly killed it, and she took flour, and kneaded it and baked unleavened bread of it, and she put it before Saul and his servants; and they ate. Then they rose and went away that night.

Responsorial. *Car. 1 Char. 10: 13, 14*

R: Saul died because of his unfaithfulness: he had not listened to the command of the Lord, * and God transferred the kingdom to David.

V: Saul had consulted a spirit through a seer, lacking in faith in the Lord,

R: and God transferred the kingdom to David.

Second Reading. *Book 2, hom.3*

Brothers, try to meditate on the word of God.

A reading from the "Homilies on Ezekiel" of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

I beg you, dearest brothers, try to meditate the words of God, you do not want to despise the writings of our Creator, which have been

transmitted. It is a great thing that through them the soul reawakens itself to the heat in order not to become sluggish to the cold of its wickedness.

When we know how the just man of the past age had acted with strength, we also are solicited to accomplish good generously, and the soul of he who reads is enflamed by the examples of the saints.

Do we desire to persevere in humility in order to conserve the innocence, even if we are offended by the neighbour? Let Abel, of whom it is written that he was killed by his brother and who did not offer resistance, come before our eyes. Are we prompt to place before our present gains the precepts of God? Let Noah who, postponing the care of his own family, by the command of the Lord almighty spent hundred years occupied completely in the construction of the ark.

Do we make efforts to embrace the virtue of obedience? We must look at Abraham who abandoning his house, his family, country, obeyed going out towards the place that he was to receive in inheritance and he left without knowing where he was going; keeping in mind the inheritance he showed himself ready to sacrifice the beloved heir that he had received. And since he did not withdraw himself from offering to the Lord his only son, he received a multitude of peoples as his descendants.

Do we desire to dilate our hearts in benevolence placing aside every sentiment of enmity? Let us recall to mind Samuel who, rejected by the people as leader, when the people themselves asked him to pray to the Lord, answered: "As for me, may I never sin against the Lord, omitting to entreat for you" (1 Sam. 12: 23). That holy man believed that he would be really at fault if through prayer he had not given back the goodness of the grace to those who had been his adversaries up to the point of refusing him. He again, sent by order of the Lord to anoint David as king, answered: "How can I go? Saul will come to know and he will kill me" (1 Sam. 16: 2) and yet, knowing that God was angry with the same Saul, he was so afflicted for him that the Lord said to him: "How long will you cry for Saul, while I have repudiated him?" (1 Sam. 16:1).

Consider how much his heart was lit up with the ardour of charity, if he cried even for the one by whom he was afraid of being killed. Do we therefore want to see who we have to fear? Promptly we must not think of not rendering evil for evil to him from whom we are fleeing, even when the occasion presents itself to us. Let us remember David, who having found himself in the position to kill the king who was persecuting him, yet, though

having the possibility of striking him, chose the good that he himself had to do, not the evil that Saul deserved to suffer and said: “The Lord forbid that I should stretch out my hand over him, because he is the Lord’s consecrated” (1 Sam. 24: 7). And when the same Saul was then killed by the enemies, he who bore him as a persecutor in life, cried for him in death.

Should we decide to speak freely to the powerful of this world who err? Let us call to mind the authority of John, who rebuking the evil of Herod was not afraid to be killed for the uprightness of his word. And since Christ is the truth, he gave his life for Christ, because he gave it for the truth.

Responsorial. *Ps. 118: 104, 105; Jn. 6: 68*

R: I hate all deceitful ways. * Your word is the light for my steps, the light on my way.

V: Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life.

R: Your word is the light for my steps, the light on my way.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Pr. 31: 10 – 31*

Eulogy of the strong woman.

A good wife who can find? She is far more precious than jewels. The heart of her husband trusts in her, and he will have no lack of gain.

She does him good, and not harm, all the days of her life. She seeks wool and flax, and works with willing hands.

She is like the ships of the merchant, she brings her food from afar. She rises while it is yet night and provides food for her household and tasks for her maidens.

She considers a field and buys it; with the fruit of her hands she plants a vineyard. She girds her loins with strength and makes her arms strong. She perceives that her merchandise is profitable. Her lamp does not go out at night. She puts her hands to the distaff, and her hands hold the spindle.

She opens her hand to the poor, and reaches out her hands to the needy. She is not afraid of snow for her household, for all her household are clothed in scarlet. She makes herself coverings; her clothing is fine linen and purple. Her husband is known in the gates, when he sits among the

elders of the land. She makes linen garments and sells them; she delivers girdles to the merchant. Strength and dignity are her clothing, and she laughs at the time to come.

She opens her mouth with wisdom, and the teaching of kindness is on her tongue. She looks well to the ways of her household, and does not eat the bread of idleness. Her children rise up and call her blessed; her husband also, and he praises her: "Many women have done excellently, but you surpass them all."

Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised. Give her of the fruit of her hands, and let her works praise her in the gates.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Prov. 31: 17, 18; Ps. 45: 6*

R: She girds her loins with energy, and makes her arms strong. * Her lamp will not go out forever.

V: God is in her: she cannot waver; he will help her before morning.

R: Her lamp will not go out forever.

Second Reading. *Disc. For Epiphany.*

The holy people, prepared by the Lord.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Aelred, abbot.

Let us see what order is followed for the celebration of the wedding. One wants to take as his wife a woman who is suitable for him. He chooses one among many, sends the intermediaries who prepare the ground for the marriage, who praise his beauty there, magnify his riches, speak of his wisdom. In this way the woman is enflamed with love for him. Love makes desire arise, the desire brings to the personal knowledge and this to consent; and thus the wedding is celebrated. Different food and drink is prepared, the animals are killed and great quantities of delicious things are procured.

Let us now lift up our gaze and from the material things let us pass to the spiritual. The Son of God, God himself in the womb of the Father and king of all the kingdoms, from his dwelling turned his gaze on all the inhabitants of the earth, and among all he saw "One" and immediately: Her beauty was pleasing to the king (cfr. Ps. 44:12). Who is she? I will tell you

in a clear way so that you may understand. It is dealing with that holy society, chosen before the creation of the world, predestined and called to justification, to glorification. In what way did he see? Not like us, to whom the past is hidden, the future is unknown, to whom the realities that are in front of our eyes are clear only with difficulty. He sees clearly that holy society from the first to the last elect. Not one after the other, but contemporarily, in every instant and always. She for him is black, but snow white because of him; for her beauty is exposed to the demons, but is prepared by him for his sweetest embrace. He has chosen her and loved her not for his own convenience, but in order to wash her of her dirt, to cure her of her sickness, to free her from her slavery, to make her happy in her poverty by uniting her to himself.

And since the beloved has to return freely the love of the one who loves her, he sent messengers who spoke of him, who praised his beauty, who magnified his wisdom, who exalted his power and riches. He therefore had messengers who revealed his secrets, showing in an ineffable light the mystery of his incarnation, the depth of the election, the vastness of the call, the height of the promise and the length of the waiting. And so, that which they had apprehended through revelation, being capable of understanding “the width, the length, the height and the depth” (Ep. 3: 18), these things they taught to the others. In fact, although the blessed society of the elect is only one, for which it is said: “One is my dove” (Sg. of Sgs. 6: 9), yet they were called messengers of the Lord because inspired by him they preached his coming.

Now we see how these messengers kindle the love of the elected bride for the Lord. The holy Moses speaking of her said: “The Lord your God will raise up for you a prophet like me; to him you will listen” (Deut. 18: 15).

“Like me” he says. For those times this was great praise. What faith in fact would not have been then kindled with love for the Christ, knowing that he would be similar to Moses? Jeremiah also did not silence his praises, when he said: “You are great, and great is the power of your name. Among all the wise men of the nations and in all their kingdoms there is no one similar to you” (Jer. 10:6, 7).

Therefore brothers, such testimonies of the Scripture are enough, so that even with these few words the spirit of the bride can be kindled with love for him. Love excites desire, the spiritual desire merits his coming and

so, through faith, the mutual consent is worked: and behold, the wedding banquet is prepared.

Responsorial. *Is. 60: 21; 62: 12*

R: All your people will be just, they will possess the land forever: * shoot of the plantation of the Lord, work of his hands to show his glory.

V: They will be called holy people, redeemed of the Lord;

R: shoot of the plantation of the Lord, work of his hands to show his glory.

Gospel. *Mt. 10: 24 – 33*

Do not fear those who kill the body.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"A disciple is not above his teacher, nor a servant above his master; it is enough for the disciple to be like his teacher, and the servant like his master. If they have called the master of the house Be-el'zebul, how much more will they malign those of his household. "So have no fear of them; for nothing is covered that will not be revealed, or hidden that will not be known. What I tell you in the dark, utter in the light; and what you hear whispered, proclaim upon the housetops. And do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul; rather **fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell**. Are not two sparrows sold for a penny? And not one of them will fall to the ground without your Father's will. But even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear not, therefore; you are of more value than many sparrows.

So every one who acknowledges me before men, I also will acknowledge before my Father who is in heaven; but whoever denies me before men, I also will deny before my Father who is in heaven.